Daily briefs · 26 October 2026

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Syria Narrative Tracker · as of the last update, 26 October 2026, 23:55 UTC

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1. The day at a glance

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Angry The dominant story overnight was Jordan's retaliatory airstrikes on southern Syria after the Karak church attack, which killed civilians in Daraa and triggered a border closure and Syrian government protest. Public reaction split sharply between Syrians condemning Jordan for killing women and children, Jordanians defending the strikes, and many invoking sectarian or geopolitical conspiracy theories. Other threads included continued fallout from attacks on Kurdish returnees in Tal Abyad, a drone strike killing an al-Qaeda-linked commander near Qastal, arrests of former regime officials, and controversy over new school curricula and Druze politics.

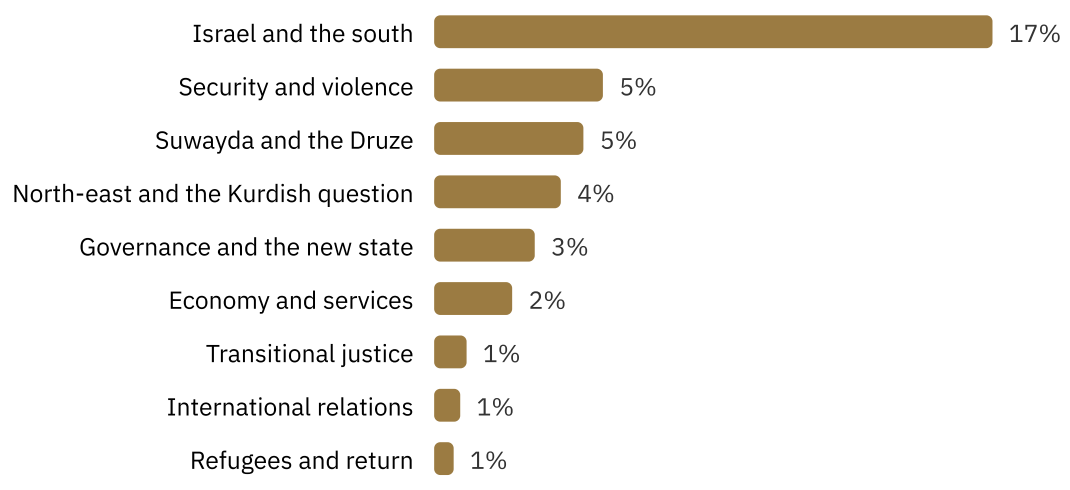
2. What people said

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The day in numbers

Leaning negative	Mostly neutral	17	3,624	6
People's tone	Outlets' tone	stories followed	post analyses	updates

Share of discussion by theme



The day's stories

1. **Jordan's deadly airstrikes on Daraa spark crisis with Damascus** Israel and the south · People: strongly negative · Outlets: leaning negative · 58% of the discussion
   Jordan's air force struck sites in rural Daraa on 26 October, calling it retaliation for an attack on a Karak church that killed nine people. Syrian officials said the strikes killed at least 7-10 civilians, including children, and were carried out without prior coordination. Damascus closed the Nassib border crossing and opened an investigation.

2. **Israeli incursions and military exercises continue in Quneitra and Daraa** Israel and the south · People: leaning negative · Outlets: leaning negative · 10% of the discussion
   Israeli forces resumed digging works on the 'Sufa 53' line near Quneitra and conducted a two-day military exercise with low-altitude flights over Daraa's Yarmouk basin. Enab Baladi reported threats to Quneitra farmers' livelihoods, and villagers in Jamleh (Daraa) appealed to Syrian authorities to stop the incursions. US envoy reportedly told Israel to halt operations as it pushes deeper into Quneitra.

3. **Attacks on Kurdish families returning to Tal Abyad** North-east and the Kurdish question · People: leaning negative · Outlets: leaning negative · 10% of the discussion
   Kurdish families returning to homes in Tal Abyad (Kobani countryside, Raqqa) faced attacks, vehicle burnings and threats, prompting over 100 families to be evacuated to Kobani. The Kurdish National Council and north-east officials demanded an investigation; Raqqa's internal security command pledged accountability.

4. **Suwayda-Damascus standoff continues amid US-Israel friction over Druze** Suwayda and the Druze · People: leaning negative · Outlets: leaning negative · 10% of the discussion
   Tensions over Suwayda and Druze leader Sheikh Hikmat al-Hijri persist, with Lebanese Druze leader Walid Jumblatt publicly criticizing al-Hijri as an Israeli tool and warning of Israeli expansion toward Damascus. A report noted continuing US-Israel policy differences over Syria's Druze issue.

5. **Lira slides and diesel shortage anger deepen** Economy and services · People: strongly negative · Outlets: mostly neutral · 9% of the discussion
   The Syrian pound fell further against the dollar on Monday, gold prices rose, and an economist proposed an early-warning inflation index, according to Shaam News and Enab Baladi. Public commenters continued venting about diesel shortages and price hikes months after the fall of the former regime, alongside scattered diesel delivery news in Aleppo.

6. **Drone strike kills al-Qaeda-linked commander near Qastal/Qara on Damascus-Homs highway** Security and violence · People: mostly neutral · Outlets: mostly neutral · 6% of the discussion
   A car explosion, later identified as a drone/missile strike, killed Abu Abdulrahman al-Libi, a commander of the dissolved Hurras al-Din (al-Qaeda affiliate), near Qastal/Qara on the Damascus-Homs highway on 26 October. Three people died; remnants suggested a US Hellfire missile.

7. **Explosions heard near Damascus amid reported Israeli drone activity** Security and violence · People: leaning negative · Outlets: leaning negative · 6% of the discussion
   Explosions were heard around Damascus near al-Kiswah and Sahnaya, accompanied by Israeli drone flights, with causes and casualties unconfirmed. Hawar News and OSINT accounts flagged the incident as significant, while SANA later reported a separate explosion on the Damascus-Homs highway the same day.

8. **Education Ministry curriculum changes spark controversy over Ottoman history and women's representation** Governance and the new state · People: leaning negative · Outlets: mostly neutral · 6% of the discussion
   Syria's new school curriculum reportedly removes anti-Ottoman references (like the 'Butcher of Arabs' label for Jamal Pasha) and alters depictions related to women, triggering debate among Syrians about identity and the transitional government's priorities.

9. **Arrests of Assad's cousin and former regime officers over war crimes** Transitional justice · Outlets: leaning positive · 4% of the discussion
   Syria's Interior Ministry announced the arrest of Yahya al-Assad and several former regime officers in Homs, including figures linked to the 2013 Tadamon massacre and alleged city bombings, as part of ongoing transitional justice efforts.

10. **Public divided over steep hike in traffic fines** Governance and the new state · People: mostly neutral · Outlets: mostly neutral · 4% of the discussion
    A proposal to raise traffic fines sharply, reportedly up to $500, continues to divide Syrians, as covered by Syria TV. Some commenters support it as necessary discipline, while others call it disconnected from people's incomes and daily hardships.

11. **Viral quote on Israeli settler claims over Jordan, Lebanon and Syria sparks alarm** Israel and the south · People: strongly negative · Outlets: strongly negative · 4% of the discussion
    A widely shared quote attributed to an American-Israeli settler, telling a Guardian journalist Palestinians can go anywhere 'except Jordan, Lebanon and Syria because those are ours too,' spread rapidly among English-language social media users. Commenters linked it to Israel's Oct. 27 election and existing incursions in Syria, framing it as evidence of expansionist intent.

12. **Landmine blasts continue to injure and kill children as map prepared** Security and violence · Outlets: leaning negative · 2% of the discussion
    Three children were injured by a landmine near al-Aboush village, Tal Tamr countryside north of Hasakah, on 26 October while herding sheep, North Press reported. Separately, a child was killed and his mother and uncle injured in an explosion in Hama countryside. Syria's Emergency Ministry said the country's first landmine contamination map will be released soon.

13. **Foreign Minister Shaibani visits Bahrain, king voices support for Syria's unity** International relations · People: leaning positive · Outlets: strongly positive · 2% of the discussion
    Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shaibani met Bahrain's King Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa, discussing regional developments and bilateral ties. The king praised Syria's positions supporting Bahrain and affirmed Manama's support for Syria's unity and sovereignty; the two sides agreed to reactivate a joint committee and expand banking cooperation.

14. **Gunmen kill young man near Khirbet Ghazaleh on Daraa highway** Security and violence · Outlets: leaning negative · 2% of the discussion
    Yahya Suleiman Kanaan, a construction worker from Khirbet Ghazaleh in eastern Daraa countryside, was shot dead at dawn near al-Majbal junction on the Daraa-Khirbet Ghazaleh road. Daraa 24 and Syria TV reported the killing, which follows earlier violence on the same highway in the area.

15. **Camps near Manbij close as displaced families return to Aleppo and Idlib areas** Refugees and return · Outlets: leaning positive · 2% of the discussion
    A third and final convoy of displaced families departed Manbij on 26 October, completing the return of 108 families to their areas of origin in Aleppo and Idlib countryside after the closure of the Rasm al-Qadim and Rasm al-Jadid camps. Officials say 25% of displaced people have left northern camps, as part of the Emergency Ministry's plan to end the camps file by 2027.

16. **Rojava University students press for academic independence and Kurdish-language education** North-east and the Kurdish question · People: mostly neutral · Outlets: mostly neutral · 1% of the discussion
    Students and politicians in the north-east, including at Rojava University and in Derbasiyah, call for protecting the Kurdish language, securing education in Kurdish, and enshrining it as an official language in the Syrian constitution. Calls for academic independence for the university also emerged.

17. **Tribal clashes, checkpoint killing and fuel-smuggling bust in Daraa** Security and violence · Outlets: mostly neutral · 1% of the discussion
    A tribal dispute in al-Sharaya (Lajat area) escalated into gunfire and grenade use, with Internal Security intervening; a young man, Yahya Suleiman Kanaan, was shot dead near Khirbet Ghazaleh; and authorities raided a fuel-mixing site near Izraa seizing 100,000 liters of adulterated fuel. A separate traffic accident on the Damascus-Daraa highway injured 36 people.

3. Sources and method

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